
"THE ABODE OF THE NĀGA KING": Questions of Art, Audience, and Local Deities at the Ajaṇṭā Caves

Author(s): ROBERT DECAROLI

Source: *Ars Orientalis*, 2011, Vol. 40 (2011), pp. 142-161

Published by: Freer Gallery of Art, The Smithsonian Institution and Department of the History of Art, University of Michigan

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/23075934>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



JSTOR

is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *Ars Orientalis*



“THE ABODE OF THE NĀGA KING”

Questions of Art, Audience, and Local Deities at the Ajaṇṭā Caves

1 (FACING)

Overview of the Ajaṇṭā Caves.

Photo: author

Abstract

Many questions still surround the topic of audience at the fifth century CE Buddhist caves at Ajaṇṭā, India. In particular, it is not at all clear who had access to the site or was permitted to see the lavish interior decorations. The lack of visibility inside the dark rock-cut structures only increases the number of questions about the artwork's intended audience. In considering this inaccessibility, it is possible that some of the choices pertaining to the subject matter and placement of the artwork were directed primarily by concerns over an audience that was not human. There is evidence to suggest that much of the artwork may have been intended to maintain and appease the local *nāga* deity mentioned in the Cave 16 inscription. This assertion can be supported through the preponderance of narrative imagery associated with *nāgas* (and similar beings) at the site, the shift towards the depiction of *nāgas* in subsidiary positions inside the architectural space, and through the use of so-called decorative depictions of divine and semidivine witnesses at events featuring the Buddha and bodhisattvas. Ultimately, textual evidence provided by the Chinese Buddhist pilgrims Xuanzang and Faxian supports the idea that visual imagery may have been used as an apotropaic technique to calm intemperate local gods. This use of the built environment as a means of interceding with a divine figure embodied in a sculptural form may hold important links to the development of South Asian *bhakti* practices.

OVER THE YEARS, every aspect of the Ajaṇṭā Caves, from door hinges to garland hooks, has undergone careful scrutiny by scholars eager to uncover the historical circumstances surrounding the creation and use of these spectacular caves carved into the cliffs above a bend in the Waghora River (fig. 1).¹ Despite the fascinating information and compelling conclusions this research has uncovered, some very basic aspects of the caves' history and use continue to elude us. For example, it is not at all clear who lived in or worshipped at these caves and who even saw their masterful decorations. These questions of audience have been circumstantially answered by late donative inscriptions left by merchants, which suggest Ajaṇṭā's remote location on the western Deccan Plateau may have been situated along a trade route.² Likewise, earlier inscriptions left by regional figures of authority point to a political importance assigned to this rocky canyon. Aside from these few inscriptions, however, we know surprisingly little about who lived in, worshipped at, or visited these caves.

The caves themselves appear to have been constructed in two phases. The earliest examples, which date to the second or first century BCE, are characterized by simple ground plans that are almost entirely devoid of extant decoration. The caves



2

2

Waterfall near the Ajanṭā Caves.
Photo: author

of the second phase, which date to the late fifth century CE, are somewhat more varied in design and far more elaborate in both their sculptural and painted decoration. During both phases, the caves followed two basic floor plans. The first is often identified as a *stūpa* or *caitya* hall and is recognizable by its distinctive apsidal plan. This shape was designed to hold a *stūpa* at the back of the cave and to allow for circumambulation along the perimeter of the interior space. The second, and most common, cave type is the monastic residence, or *vihāra*. These caves invariably possess a large rectangular central chamber off of which radiate several smaller monastic cells. Examples of the *vihāra* plan that date to the second phase of construction also contain prominent shrines to the Buddha located along their back walls. Some variations on these general plans do occur at the site, but most caves conform to these core features of architectural design.

As Walter Spink has demonstrated, most of the caves of the second phase of construction show remarkably few signs of habitation or long-term occupation, which further compounds the questions surrounding their use.³ In some cases the decorative programs within specific caves have been examined in hope that the nature of the visual narratives and programmatic decoration might reveal something of their patronage or intended audience. Most notably, some scholars have linked Caves 1 and 2 to the Vākāṭaka ruler Hariṣeṇa, based in part on the observation that most of the narrative scenes in these caves pertain to kings and rulers.⁴ And, while this certainly may be the case, I would like to suggest that these same images, and others like them, also may have been intended for a very different type of ruler. The



3

3
Cave 16 Nāga Shrine.
Photo: John C. and Susan L.
Huntington

authority figure to which I refer has the unusual quality of not even being human. Specifically, I am referring to the *Nāga King (Nāgendra)*,⁵ which according to the Cave 16 inscription was a resident of this mountainside even prior to the creation of the Buddhist monastery.⁶ The veneration of *nāgas*, like the one resident at Ajañṭā, has a very long history in South Asia that goes back to the earliest textual and sculptural sources. These serpentine figures were local demigods associated with fertility, water, and rainfall, who could at times be angered into bringing about periods of flood or drought. In the case of Ajañṭā, the local *Nāga King* was more than likely associated initially with the Waghora River that cascades dramatically to the foot of the canyon just above the Ajañṭā Caves and makes a sharp bend along the valley floor (fig. 2).

Varāhadeva, the donor who left the Cave 16 inscription, refers to this canyon wall as having originally been “the abode of the *Nāga King*,” but he also states he personally sponsored the construction of “a dwelling” for this same *nāga*, presumably because either the monastery had infringed on its old residence or as an act of personal devotion directed to the *Nāga King* itself.⁷ This new dwelling is almost certainly the large *nāga* shrine (fig. 3) located below Cave 16 on a path leading up from the river, thereby making the *nāga* a special inhabitant of the rock-cut monastery. The simple fact that an important donor believed the *nāga* to be present literally within the monastic complex may hold intriguing implications for the way we understand the artwork at Ajañṭā. In short, I would suggest the artistic decoration throughout many portions of the Ajañṭā Caves was not solely intended for human



4

4
Nāgarāja outside Cave 19, Ajaṇṭā,
 ca. late fifth century CE. Photo: author

eyes, and in many cases the decorative programs address the supernatural as much as (if not more than) they do the human.

The visual motifs employed at Ajaṇṭā reveal an intense interest in supernatural beings and provide some insight into the complex relationship between the monastery and the local gods. Others have already written on the economic benefits of this interaction. I, however, am more concerned with what this implied supernatural audience can reveal about issues of legitimacy and the manner in which artistic representations were understood to function in social and religious contexts.⁸

Local Deities in Iconic, Narrative, and Decorative Art

Representations of local gods and spirit-deities,⁹ which include a diverse catalog of beings, such as *nāgas*, *yakṣas*, *gandharvas*, *kinnaras*, and many others, can be found in abundance throughout the site. The members of this impressive collection of supernatural figures are found in a variety of contexts, represented in both sculptural and painted forms. In some cases these figures occupy their own shrines and almost certainly served as icons for veneration. The well-known *yakṣī* Haritī and her consort Jambhala/Kubera have been given a place of prominence in Cave 2; whereas, large enshrined images of the *Nāga* King can be found in two locations—down from Cave 16 and directly outside Cave 19 (fig. 4). A shrine located just across the chamber from the image of Haritī in Cave 2 depicts two additional figures that are quite likely representations of the well-known *yakṣa* generals Maṇibhadra and Pūrṇabhadra (fig. 5).¹⁰ This attribution is not certain, but it is made more likely by



5

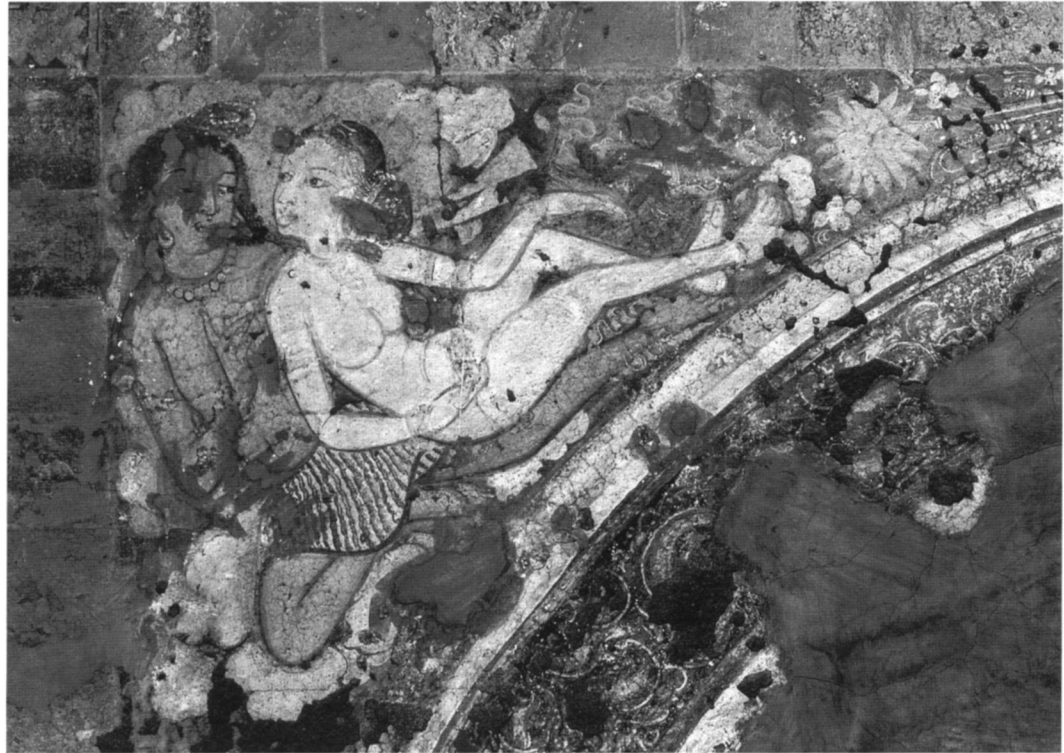
5
Mañibhadra and Pūrṇabhadra
Shrine, Cave 2. Photo: John C. and
Susan L. Huntington

the fact that a painted and labeled image of Mañibhadra was identified in Cave 17, confirming that this demigod was known and singled out for veneration elsewhere at the site.¹¹

These figures and others like them are featured prominently in narrative scenes that can be found wherever painted materials have been preserved. The narratives display a somewhat surprising number of tales involving supernatural figures and demigods. By my count, approximately half of all the narrative material that can be seen in the extant paintings across the monastic complex depicts tales that relate directly to some type of spirit-deity, and of these, more involve *nāgas* than any other type.

The vast majority of these tales are taken directly from the *Jātaka*, or tales of the Buddha's past lives. It is interesting to note that of the more than five hundred *Jātaka* tales known through textual materials, only a relatively small portion deals explicitly with supernatural beings.¹² At Ajaṇṭā, however, about half of all the narratives (and over half of all the *Jātakas* depicted) feature spirit-deities. It would seem the artists and patrons of Ajaṇṭā exhibited a preference by intentionally and predominantly selecting those tales that deal with supernatural beings for representation at the site. These *Jātaka* tales are quite diverse in their specifics, but as is typical for the genre, most involve a moral dilemma that is resolved by the future Buddha through his wisdom, generosity, and compassion. While the details always change, it is standard for them to conclude with the spirits and deities expressing their admiration for the Buddhist teachings.

Just to provide an example, I will quickly relate the story of Maitribala, which has been identified three times at Ajaṇṭā in Caves 1, 2, and 16.¹³ In this story the future Buddha is born as a king who is so righteous that dangerous *yakṣas* are actually



6

6
Flying Celestials, Cave 1.
Photo: Asian Art Archives,
University of Michigan

rendered powerless in his realm. When a group of brutish spirits confronts him, asking for human flesh to eat, the king offers them part of his own flesh and blood. The carnivorous *yakṣas* are so impressed by this behavior that they reform their evil ways and vow to behave properly in the future. At its core, this tale reinforces the protective qualities of the Buddhist teachings and their ability to tame destructive appetites, even those of predatory spirits.

Along with the iconic and narrative depictions of these supernatural beings is a third category of imagery that is easy to overlook, despite the fact these works are among the most pervasive at Ajanṭā. I am speaking of the artwork that is often categorized as decorative, even though these figures typically embellish architectural elements or adorn the edges of artwork depicting more prominent subject matter, such as narratives or images of bodhisattvas (fig. 6). With the exception of the caves dating to the second century BCE, this type of imagery is found throughout the rest of the site in both painted and sculptural forms. Representations of flying deities, divine couples, dwarf-like *ganas*, half-avian *kinnaras*, and the like can be seen acting as silent observers to the central images or to the primary narrative action. These figures often act as attendants or witnesses to the main subject matter, which make them easy to overlook or dismiss as insignificant. The prevalence of these so-called decorative images was certainly no accident, however, and it would be a mistake not to recognize them as some of the most widely represented figures at Ajanta.

Interestingly, these semidivine witnesses assembled to observe a great teacher or a miraculous event have a direct parallel in Buddhist literary sources. For example, in a passage from the *Buddhacarita* of the first or second century CE, we are presented with a description of the birth and first bath of the child who will become the Buddha. The text tells us that as the child lay on his bed,

yakṣa lords stood reverent, on guard with golden lotuses in their hands. The dwellers of heaven, themselves remaining invisible held up in the sky white umbrellas and bowing their heads in obeisance before his majesty, muttered the highest blessings that he might obtain enlightenment. The mighty snakes [*nāgas*] in their thirst for the most excellent law fanned him and with eyes shining with devotion bestrewed him with *mandāra* flowers.¹⁴

Here the authors took care to embellish their presentation of the central narrative with elaborate descriptions of the heavenly hosts who have gathered to celebrate and participate in a sacred event.

A similarly populated passage from the third-century *Lalitavistara* centers on the Śākyamuni's arrival at Bodhgaya, the location in which he will undertake his meditation and eventually achieve enlightenment. The text relates that the gods Brahmā, Śakra, and the four directional guardians (*lokapāla*), with the assistance of sixteen *devaputra*, prepared the seat of the future Buddha. When they had done so, "the gods, *nāgas*, *yakṣas*, *gandharvas*, and *asuras* compared their own abodes to cemeteries and expressed their admiration."¹⁵ Once again, the importance of the event is underscored and validated by the presence of a host of supernatural witnesses. This literary trope is incredibly common in the Buddhist textual sources. In fact, this same text, the *Lalitavistara*, contains a chapter comprised almost entirely of supernatural and divine figures praising the Buddha on achieving enlightenment.¹⁶

The tendency to mark noteworthy events or signify the importance of individuals with an entourage or assembly of divine and spiritually powerful figures is equally strong within most Mahāyāna *sūtras*. It is rather standard protocol in these texts that each sermon or miraculous display is prefaced with an elaborate description of the noteworthy figures present at the auspicious event. If we take the *Vimalakīrti-nirdeśa Sūtra* as an example, the text sets the stage for the Buddha's sermon by providing a long description of those present. One section states:

There were also gathered there ten thousand Brahmās, at their head Brahmā Sikhin, who had come from the Aśoka universe with its four sectors to see, venerate, and serve the Buddha and to hear the Dharma from his own mouth. There were twelve thousand Śakras, from various four-sector universes. And there were other powerful gods: *Brahmās*, *Śakras*, *Lokapālas*, *devas*, *nāgas*, *yakṣas*, *gandharvas*, *asuras*, *garuḍas*, *kimnaras*, and *mahoragas*. Finally, there was the fourfold community, consisting of *bhikṣus*, *bhikṣuṇīs*, laymen, and laywomen.¹⁷

In each of these circumstances, an event in the Buddha's life or the occasion of a profound revelation of *dhārma* is highlighted by a complex and extended description of the audience and its supernatural membership. These litanies of impressive witnesses prepare the reader for the significance of the events that follow and heighten the spiritual impact of the story. The sanctity of the event is reinforced and attested through the presence of this host of heavenly adherents and august beings.

In both the literature and the artwork, these observers are admittedly secondary to the main event and the central actor, but they play a vital role in establishing and foreshadowing the profound nature of the event that is about to occur. If the frequency with which these divine observers are depicted at Ajaṇṭā is any indication, this type of validation may have been a dominant mode of visually indicating importance. As such, it would be a mistake to dismiss such figures as merely decorative and not recognize the manner in which such figures were employed to construct sanctity and convey legitimacy—yet their presence in these paintings may convey a second message as well. The artwork reinforces the notion that even the gods and spirits are eager to enjoy the benefits of following the Buddha's *dhārma*.

Nāgas at Ajaṇṭā

Nāgas are featured so prominently at the Ajaṇṭā Caves that at this point it may be helpful to concentrate exclusively on representations of these ophidian demi-gods. The *Nāga* King is the only supernatural being (apart from the Buddha) who is explicitly mentioned in inscriptions as a resident of the site, and the narrative imagery focuses particular attention on beings like him. It seems likely that *nāgas*, and the *Nāga* King in particular, were understood as having a special relationship to Ajaṇṭā. A closer look at the manner in which *nāgas* are represented may provide some insight.

As was previously noted, two large shrines dedicated to *Nāgas* are found at the site. The first of these, Cave 16, is located below the *vihāra* hall, and its donor mentions the *Nāga* King in his inscription (fig. 3). Cave 19, the second shrine, is located just outside the *stūpa* hall (fig. 4). In both cases a central male *nāga* with multiple serpent hoods is seated in a posture of “royal ease,” with one leg up and the other hanging down. This posture is a standard means of indicating kingship and power in South Asia. Additionally, in both examples the *nāga* is seated on a high platform, and in one case he is attended by two female *nāgas* (*nāginīs*), each of whom has only a single serpent hood. The high platforms, reclining postures, multiple hoods, and attendant figures borrow from the imagery of kingship and signify a *nāga* of elevated status. Most likely, both were intended as representations of the *Nāga* King mentioned in the Cave 16 inscriptions, although it is certainly possible that two different *Nāga* Kings are being depicted.



7
Nāga at Shrine Entrance, Cave 20.
Photo: American Institute of Indian
Studies (AIIS)

These large *nāga* shrines are both located on the edges of Buddhist sacred space and presumably served as sites for devotion directed to the *Nāga* King himself. Inside the Buddhist space of the *vihāras* and *stūpa* halls, however, the representations of *nāgas* cease to function as clear objects of devotion and are more frequently participants in narrative scenes or are shown as subsidiary attendants. This can be seen sculpturally in Caves 1 and 20 (figs. 7 and 12), where beautifully carved but small *nāgas* stand on either side of the entryways to the main Buddha shrines that occupy the backs of these *vihāras*. A variation of this arrangement is also found in Caves 2 and 6. The upper registers of the two pillars flanking the path to the shrine in Cave 2 have been painted to depict seated *nāgarājas*, each served by three attendants.¹⁸ In the lower Cave 6, the same conceptual plan seems to be at work. Here, a *nāgarāja* has been prominently carved on the lintel of the doorway leading to the Buddha shrine. Additionally, a similar arrangement of artistic details has been noted by Leela Aditi Wood in Cave 17. She identifies the entire shrine antechamber as “Kubera’s realm” and constructs the way spirit-deities have been mapped onto the architectural space leading to the Buddha’s image. Among this imagery she identifies the presence of “Nāga Kings bearing fly whisks” that “stand on the half-sized front faces of the pilaster capitals.”¹⁹ Cave 26 also displays a distinctive sculptural *nāga* with attendants, but in this case the image has been placed inside the porch of the *stūpa* hall rather than outside the shrine, as was the case in the *vihāras*.

In these interior spaces the *nāgas* are transformed from objects of devotion into devotees. They cease to be the objects of worship in these contexts and are instead represented as adherents or guardians of the Buddhist Law, venerating the Blessed One alongside human visitors to the site. Some examples from the wall paintings help to make this point.

In Cave 1, several “decorative” images represent *nāgas* in both human and serpent form doing honor to *stūpas*. Additionally, four tales about *nāgas* are depicted on the walls, not including a fifth tale that features a *nāga* in a life scene of the Buddha, which will be discussed later.²⁰ Among these tales are included a possible version of the story of Sudhana, in which a hunter agrees to help protect a lake-dwelling *nāga* from a snake charmer and thereby earns his gratitude, and the *Campaka* or *Campeya Jātaka* (fig. 8), which tells another tale of rescue involving the *nāga* of the Campa River who is liberated from captivity.²¹ Specifically, the latter tale begins when the *nāga* Campaka, finding it hard to concentrate on his meditations while surrounded by the luxuries of the *nāga* world, decides to travel to the human world in order to escape the distractions. Once there, he assumes his serpent form and is captured by a snake charmer. Campaka cannot escape because he is committed to non-violence and will not fight his way to freedom. Finally, a merchant recognizes



8

8

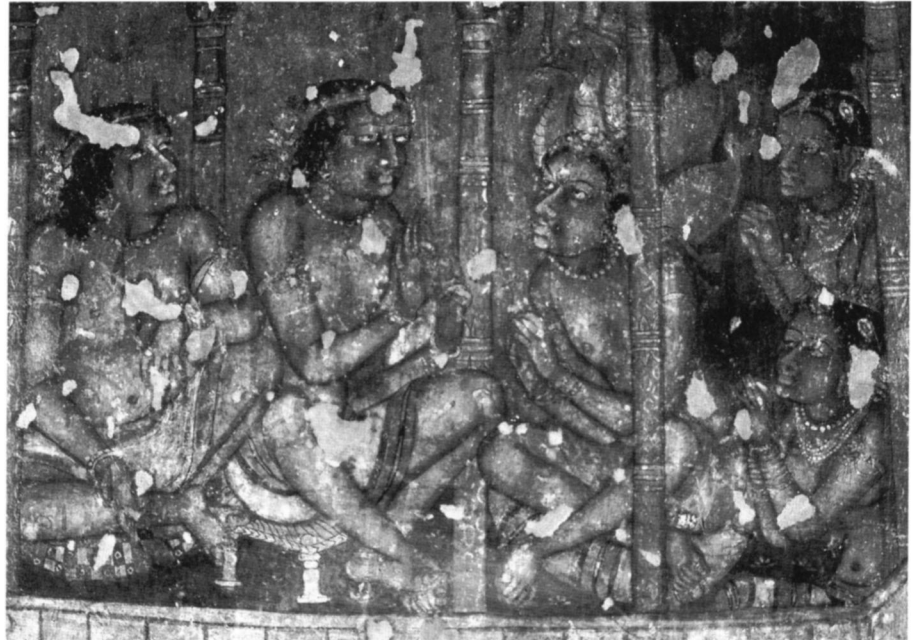
Campeya Jātaka, Cave 1.
Photo: Suresh Vasant, Asian Art
Archives, University of Michigan

the *nāga* as more than an ordinary snake and purchases him from his captors.²² The two become friends, and the *nāga* preaches the value of Buddhist virtues.

The *Śaṅkhapāla Jātaka*, seen on the northeastern wall of Cave 1, tells a remarkably similar story, only in this case the *nāga* is captured by hunters and is freed through the efforts of his *nāginī* wife and a human king.²³ The final *nāga*-related narrative, seen on the southeastern wall of the main chamber in Cave 1, is possibly the *Nāgakumāra Avadāna*, which tells the story of a monk who had been a *nāga* in his past life. Out of a sense of dedication, he travels to the *nāga* realm in order to teach his former father, who benefits from the instruction on Buddhism.²⁴

The walls of Cave 2 contain two additional tales of *nāgas*. One is the exceptionally complex *Vidhūrapaṇḍita Jātaka*, in which the fame of the wise and virtuous Vidhura is so great that a *nāga* queen devises an elaborate plan just to arrange an opportunity for him to preach in her presence (fig. 9).²⁵ This tale is depicted on the right-hand wall when facing the back of the cave (roughly southeast), occupying a space above and between three cell doors. The final tale is another complicated story called the *Bhūridatta Jātaka*, which is depicted on the walls of the cave's southeastern porch cell. Here, a ruler is forced to marry his daughter to a *nāga* king. The son born of this union seeks out the human world for meditation, and as with the *nāgas* in the other tales, he only finds captivity. Eventually he triumphs, preaches the dharma to the assembled *nāgas*, and forgives those who mistreated him.²⁶

Although these tales differ in significant ways, the narrative action in each revolves around a *nāga* who seeks moral improvement through a sermon, meditation, or a commitment to virtuous behavior. The *nāga* protagonists are generally adherents of the Buddhist moral code and are either reminded of this moral position by the humans or conversely take the time to instruct the humans on proper behavior. Rather than being represented as objects of devotion, these tales portray *nāgas* as seekers of higher spiritual states who, like humans, can benefit greatly from the Buddha's teachings.



9

9

Vidhūrapaṇḍita Jātaka, Cave 2.
Photo: Suresh Vasant, Asian Art
Archives, University of Michigan

The assertion that the creators and donors at Ajaṇṭā had a preference for tales involving *nāgas* finds some further support in scenes intended to depict events from the life of the Buddha himself. In many cases, the artists have chosen to highlight the participation of *nāgas* at the core events in the Buddha's biography. The presence of *nāgas* at these moments is mentioned in some of the literary sources, but it was by no means mandatory or even typical to depict them in the artwork. Here at Ajaṇṭā, special accommodations seem to have been made in order to ensure these beings were included whenever possible.

Taking the imagery from Caves 16 and 17, we can see representations of the prince Siddhartha engaged in an archery contest, the First Sermon, a scene of the Buddha preaching in Indra's heaven, and two possible representations of the Great Miracle at Śrāvastī. In each of these paintings, versions of the stories were chosen in which *nāgas* are mentioned, and the artists have made a point of including them in the visual depiction of the events.

Images of the Great Miracle at Śrāvastī (or *Mahāprātihārya*) occur quite frequently at Ajaṇṭā, but most of these works are later, intrusive sculptural additions to the site (fig. 10).²⁷ However, at least three instances of this motif have been preserved in painting (Caves 2, 16, and 17), and a few sculptural examples still exist from the time of the caves' initial excavation. The motif of the Great Miracle remained remarkably uniform over time, and a single event from this complicated narrative seems to have quickly become the accepted means of visually representing the story, despite the fact that this specific event does not occur in every version of the tale. To summarize, rivals representing a different religious order challenge the Buddha to a competition of miracles. Over the course of the next day, the Buddha magically makes a man fly, creates a supernatural conflagration, emits golden light, causes an earthquake, summons deities, rises into the air, and brings fire and water from his body. Despite this sequence of visually stunning miracles, the specific moment selected for depiction at Ajaṇṭā occurs towards the end of the events as told in the *Divyāvadāna*. The passage states that the *nāgas* Nanda and Upananda



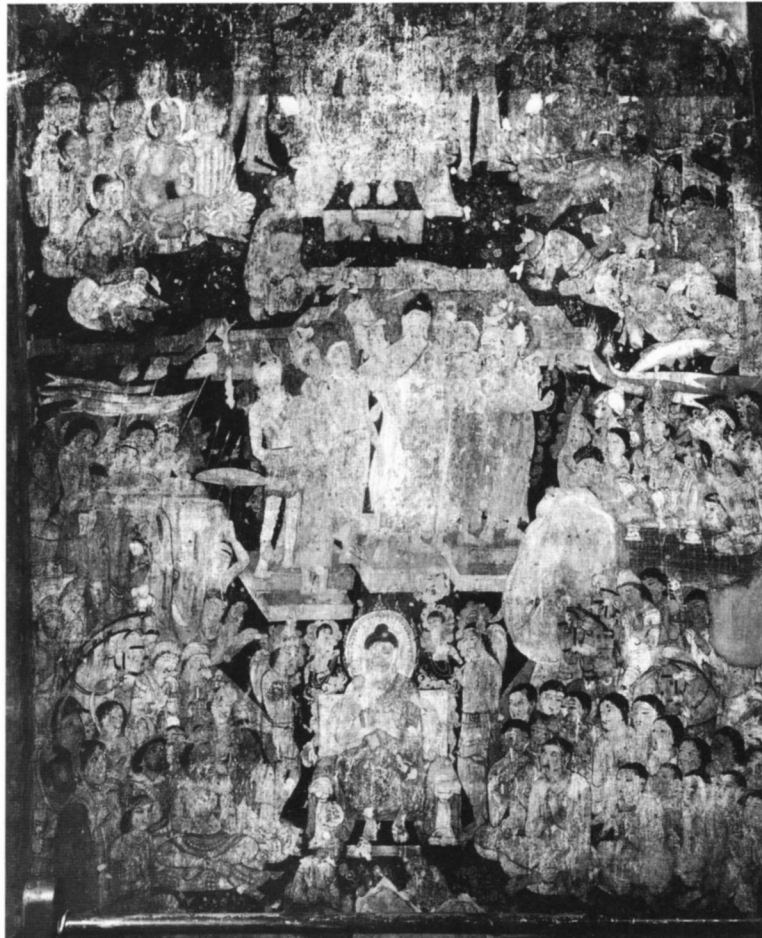
10

10

Great Miracle at Śrāvastī, Cave 26.
Photo: John C. and Susan L.
Huntington

wished to honor the Buddha so they lifted him on a lotus made of precious metals. Seated in this manner, the Buddha multiplies himself and fills the sky with his images.²⁸ Significantly, it is this moment, in which two *nāgas* exalt the status of the Buddha, that was selected as a standard encapsulation of the entire complicated tale. Iconographically, this scene creates a visual hierarchy in which the large image of the seated Buddha is placed above the two smaller figures of the *nāgas*, who are frequently shown making gestures of reverence. This same pair of *nāgas*, Nanda and Upananda, is depicted in a second narrative seen near the front of the cave on the northwestern wall of Cave 2. In this example, they are part of a painting depicting the events that occur in relation to Siddhartha's birth, and the two *nāgas* (identified in the textual accounts) are shown presenting the water used to bathe the newborn prince.²⁹

In Cave 16, in an interesting painted depiction of the Buddha preaching, two *nāgas* in postures of reverence are seated directly in front of the Buddha. Located just behind a group of monks but at the head of a large crowd of listeners, these *nāgas* occupy a visually prominent part of the composition.³⁰ Additionally, Cave 16 contains an image depicting Siddhartha's youth in the palace.³¹ In this rather unique scene, the prince has shot an arrow through his target, through some trees, and deep enough into the earth to bring forth a spring of water. In the painting a *nāga*, who presumably embodies the newly created freshwater spring, returns the arrow to Siddhartha.



11

11

Preaching in Indra's Heaven
(the *nāgas* are located to the upper
right of the central Buddha), Cave 17.
Photo: American Institute of Indian
Studies (AIIS)

A similar type of image in which the presence of water provides an opportunity to depict *nāgas* in the Buddha's presence can be seen in Cave 9.³² In the course of this story detailing the Buddha's conversion of the sage Kāśyapa, the god Indra creates a spring so that the Buddha can perform his ablutions. The creators of the painting may have intended to represent the brook in the form of two *nāgas* emerging from beneath the seated Buddha. This example, like the others, demonstrates the artists' tendency to highlight visually moments that associate *nāgas* with the Buddha and to emphasize or reinforce the *nāgas*' eagerness to support his actions.

One last example of the manner in which *nāgas* have been connected with the biography of the Buddha can be seen in Cave 17. In this case the story takes place in Indra's heaven (*Trāyastriṃśa*), where the Buddha traveled in order to preach to his mother, who had died while he was still young (fig. 11).³³ This scene presents a massive crowd of beings that has assembled to hear the Buddha's sermon. In the right-hand side of the composition is a depiction of two *nāgas* startled from their prayers by the arrival of a mortal enemy, a hawk-like demigod called a *garuḍa*. In the Mūlasarvāstivādin version of this tale, however, the *garuḍa* announces that the *nāgas* are safe since it would not dare take a life during the Buddha's sermon. What I find interesting about this tale is its emphasis on the benefits and protections *nāgas* enjoy simply by being in the presence of the Buddha. Whereas the other tales stress how devoted and loyal the *nāgas* are to the Buddha, this example suggests the benefits of that devotion.



12

12

Main shrine, Cave 1.
Photo: American Institute
of Indian Studies (AIIS)

If the frequent depiction of tales related to popular deities is indeed the outcome of an intentional process of selection, this begs the question, why? In order to answer this, it is important to understand how figural images were understood to function within South Asian religious contexts. Rather than simply being decoration, these images were believed to have an inherent link to what they represented.³⁴ Stories that describe an occasion in which the Buddha's own statue rises to greet him, such as the one in the *Paññāsa Jātaka*, help to reinforce the idea that these images were assigned far more agency than is typically acknowledged.³⁵ For example, recent scholarship has shown that images of the Buddha (fig. 12) were treated as legal entities in the Mūlasārvastivādin monastic code (*vinaya*). These images literally "resided" in the *vihāra* with the other monks and were allowed to own property on their own behalf.³⁶ Some of these same notions are reflected in the Cave 26 inscription at Ajaṇṭā by the monk Buddhahadra. He states that the Buddha "has won the state free of old-age and death and has departed for the City of Tranquility ... and yet he accomplishes the aims of living beings. That is why extolling [his] qualities in homage is efficacious ... a single flower offered to him is a primary cause for the fruits known as heaven and final emancipation."³⁷

156 ROBERT DECAROLI

In this inscription, Buddhābhaddra acknowledges that the Buddha has departed for nirvana but also emphasizes that offerings made directly to him are still capable of producing positive results. If this kind of immediacy is attributed to the Buddha, who has achieved his *parinirvāṇa*, how much more tangible must have been the presence of figures like the *nāgas*, who were understood as being very much part of the here and now.³⁸ Yet, the presence of such demigods within the monastic complex almost certainly would have generated some unease. These beings were known for their capricious natures, and it seems likely that the public would look for comfort in assurances of the *nāgas*' continued favor and restraint.

Indeed, this anxiety can be seen in the textual records left by Xuanzang, a Chinese Buddhist pilgrim to India in the early seventh century. He relates the story of a lake-dwelling *nāga* who reforms his malicious ways but fears that he will forget his promise to behave properly. He states, "The nature of *Nāgas* is fierce and wicked, so that they are unable to control themselves; if by chance an angry heart arises in me it will be from forgetfulness of our present compact." To prevent this, he instructs the human king to leave a drum at a lakeside monastery. The monks in residence were enjoined to beat the drum whenever they saw dark clouds forming, and this sound served to remind the *nāga* of his promise to behave.³⁹ Xuanzang tells a similar tale of a murderous *nāga* named Gopāla, who was converted by the Buddha himself. This *nāga* also fears that he might backslide into his old ways. The Buddha, therefore, leaves him his shadow, stating, "If an evil heart arises in you, you must look at my shadow, and because of its power of love and virtue your evil purpose will be stopped."⁴⁰ As in the previous tale, the *nāga* fears his own nature and relies on external reminders in order to assure proper behavior. A related circumstance was recorded by the fourth-century pilgrim Faxian. He describes a monastery that is protected by a benign *nāga* who ensures good rains and harvests. In gratitude for this service, the *nāga* was built a "house" in the monastery, and he was given a daily blessing by monks, some of whom were required to eat in his residence.⁴¹ In this example, the *nāga* is maintained, housed, and fed by the monastery in exchange for his continued favor. There is no doubt that the *nāga* is in the service of the monastery, but it is also clear that the monks have obligations to him as well, which ensured his continued compliance.

Given these concerns, it is plausible that the construction of a Buddhist spiritual hierarchy required visible signs of ongoing vigilance. We know that the *Nāga* King at Ajaṇṭā received gifts, such as the "dwelling" offered by the donor of Cave 16 (fig. 3), and yet he was also supplanted from his position as the sole resident of this valley. His presence at the outskirts of the monastery implies a hierarchy in which the Buddha and his teachings occupy the apex. This leaves the *nāga* in a rather liminal space wherein visitors to the site could both worship the *nāga* and worship

alongside him. It is in this ill-defined context that the artwork may have played a useful role. Images and narratives may have functioned simultaneously as public reminders of Buddhism's authority and as an apotropaic means of regulating the behavior of spirit-deities, like the shadow and drums in the stories. Additionally, the monastic institution gained legitimacy through this association with spirits and gods, much in the same way the "decorative" examples of these spirit-deities signified value in the artistic and literary contexts mentioned earlier. Ultimately, the public gained assurances of the ongoing benevolence of local gods, who also were understood to benefit from this relationship. As members of a divine congregation, the gods gained access to the teachings of the Buddha as well as to the guidance and protection of the monastic community, both of which were seen as conducive to earning a positive rebirth and eventual liberation.

Just as the *nāgas* in the stories preserved by the Chinese pilgrims needed reminders in order to ensure continued piety, the *Nāga* King at Ajaṇṭā was literally surrounded with narratives that reinforce the value of devotion and virtue. These visual narratives repeatedly include *nāgas* and other popular deities in their injunctions for proper behavior, and they often feature these same deities as exemplars of moral practice. Looking again at the caves, the extant iconic, narrative, and decorative representations consistently represent *nāgas* and similar deities as deeply desirous of benefiting from the Buddha's teachings, and they frequently make a point of placing such beings directly in the presence of the Buddha or bodhisattvas.⁴² While these images certainly would have been comforting reminders to the public of Buddhism's success in taming local gods, I would also suggest that these images were intended for more than just a human audience. Whether the selection of these narratives was the result of monastic guidance or due entirely to the preference of individual donors, tales related to *nāgas* and other spirit-deities seem to have remained a priority. Given concern over *nāgas* relapsing into bad behavior, as expressed in the textual accounts, it is possible that this artwork was understood to be both protective and edifying. It is well established that monks at times had a hand in taming and maintaining local gods, and at Ajaṇṭā it would seem that the built environment may have helped in that process.⁴³ The visual narratives emphasize the lessons that the *nāga* realm is not conducive to enlightenment, that it is a rare treasure to be able to hear the teaching of the Buddha, and that anger leads only to suffering. Certainly these are useful lessons for anyone, but they are particularly appropriate for local gods associated with the monastery. The inscriptions make it clear that the *Nāga* King was understood to be quite literally present at the site. If this was held to be true by those artists, monks, and donors who built the site, it is, therefore, certainly worth expanding our own notions of audience to include all of the categories they would have recognized.

Such practices may, in fact, presage the well-articulated artistic traditions associated with later Hindu temple construction in which the built environment is carefully designed to be pleasing to the deity embodied during the ritual process.⁴⁴ The *darśan*, or gaze of the deity, is recognized as a primary means through which interaction with the divine may be conducted, whether through the beautiful decorations of the temple chamber, offerings of light, or simply eye contact with devotees.⁴⁵ In short, the temple itself is understood as a sacred abode within whose boundaries performance and decoration are instrumental in effective interaction with the divine.

This use of the visual as a technique for engaging the divine becomes particularly sophisticated and complex in practices associated with the Hindu *bhakti* traditions. Examples of similar processes occur in Buddhist rituals as well. For instance, Richard Gombrich discusses image-making rituals in Sri Lanka wherein great importance is placed on the first thing an image of the Buddha “sees” when its eyes are ritually opened.⁴⁶ These examples are united in their implicit assumption that regulating an image’s visual context constitutes a significant component in proper interaction with the sacred.

Simply put, in all of these cases the visual environment acts as a mechanism for influencing sacred beings embodied in sculptural form, and it may be that Ajaṇṭā and similar sites, which contain artwork that appears to have been intended for local gods, were early iterations in the development of this practice. The major distinction seems to be that, while the later traditions primarily use artwork to construct a setting worthy enough to house powerful sacred forces, the caves at Ajaṇṭā actively seek to regulate and limit the actions of the *nāgas* through their decorative programs.

Scholars have frequently suggested that the artwork associated with early Buddhist sites served a didactic as well as a decorative function. It may be prudent, however, to extend that notion by asking for whom exactly these edifying tales were intended. The answer may require us to throw open concepts of audience and blur any solid boundaries between the categories of art and viewer. It can be revealing to consider that not all art was intended exclusively, or even primarily, for human eyes.

Robert DeCaroli received his doctorate in 1999 from the University of California, Los Angeles, and now serves as associate professor of South and Southeast Asian art history at George Mason University. He is the author of the book *Haunting the Buddha: Indian Popular Religions and the Formation of Buddhism* (2004) as well as of several articles and book chapters. One of the most recent is “Shedding Skins: Nāga Imagery and Layers of Meaning in South Asian Buddhist Contexts” in *Buddhist Stūpas in South Asia* (2009). rdecarol@gmu.edu

NOTES

- 1 The quotation in the title is from the Ajaṇṭā Cave 16 inscription number 67. See Richard Scott Cohen, "Setting the Three Jewels: The Complex Culture at the Ajaṇṭā Caves" (dissertation, University of Michigan, 1995), 361.
- 2 For a complete listing of the Ajaṇṭā inscriptions see *ibid.*, Appendix A, 325–86.
- 3 Walter Spink, "The Caves at Ajanta," *Archaeology* 45, no. 6 (November–December 1992), 92, and Walter Spink, "Ajanta: A Brief History," in *Aspects of Indian Art*, ed. P. Pal (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1972), 49–58.
- 4 Walter Spink, *Ajanta: History and Development*, vol. 1 (Leiden: Brill, 2005), 194–95.
- 5 This Serpent King is also referred to as *bhujagendra* and possibly *bhujāṅga*. Cohen, "Setting the Three Jewels," Appendix A, 359–60.
- 6 *Ibid.*, 361–62: "He had a splendid dwelling for the Lord of Ascetics excavated on the finest mountain: abode of a Naga king."
- 7 Richard Cohen, "Nāga, Yakṣiṇi, Buddha: Local Deities and Local Buddhism at Ajanta," *History of Religions* 37, no. 4 (May 1998), 374.
- 8 *Ibid.*, 360–400, and Robert DeCaroli, *Haunting the Buddha: Indian Popular Religions and the Formation of Buddhism* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2004), 76–79, 175–76.
- 9 I have employed the hybrid term "spirit-deity" because this category of minor deities (such as *yakṣas*, *nāgas*, *devatās*, *gandharvas*, etc.) holds a liminal position between the realms of ghosts (*preta*, *bhūta*) and gods (*deva*), and it frequently seems to share the nature of both. I do realize that combining several categories of supernatural beings under one collective title poses certain problems. However, given the fluidity and frequency with which the primary sources use these categories interchangeably, and the uniformity in the Buddhist response to all these types of beings, it is helpful to use this term within the confines of the present discussion. For a more complete discussion see *ibid.*, 8–20.
- 10 Monika Zin, *Guide to the Ajanta Paintings: Devotional and Ornamental*, vol. 2 (New Delhi: Mushiram Manoharlal, 2003), 13.
- 11 *Ibid.*, 27.
- 12 Since the artwork at Ajaṇṭā does not seem to refer to the Pali *Jātaka*, there may have been fewer than five hundred known to the creators of the site. Even within the Sanskrit *Jātaka* tradition, however, proportionately few tales deal explicitly with supernatural beings.
- 13 Dieter Schlingloff, *Guide to the Ajanta Paintings: Narrative Wall Paintings*, vol. 1 (New Delhi: Mushiram Manoharlal, 1999), 1, 15, 32. The Cave 1 and Cave 16 identifications are fairly clear, but the Cave 2 example is so damaged that no definitive attribution is possible.
- 14 *Aśvaghoṣa's Buddhacarita, or Acts of the Buddha*, trans. E. H. Johnston (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1995), 5 (canto I, verses 17–19).
- 15 *The Lalitavistara Sūtra: The Voice of the Buddha, The Beauty of Compassion*, trans. G. Bays, vol. 2 (Berkeley: Dharma Publishing, 1983), 423.
- 16 *Ibid.*, chap. 23, 536–57.
- 17 *The Holy Teaching of Vimalakirti*, trans. Robert Thurman (University Park: Pennsylvania State University, 1976), 10–11.
- 18 Zin, *Guide to the Ajanta Paintings*, 8.
- 19 Leela Aditi Wood, "The Buddha and the Shape of Belief: Indic Visual *Jātakamālās*," vol. 1 (dissertation, University of Michigan, 2005), 515–19.
- 20 Wood identifies these "decorative" scenes of worship on the pillars of Cave 1; *ibid.*, 1049, fig. 326.

- 21 Schlingloff, *Guide to the Ajanta Paintings*, 4, 10.
- 22 For the story of Sudhana see *Divyāvadāna*, eds. E. B. Cowell and R. A. Neil (Cambridge: Cambridge Press, 1886), 30, and see also *Heavenly Exploits: Buddhist Biographies from the Divyāvadāna*, trans. J. Tatelman, vol. 1 (New York: New York University Press and Clay Sanskrit Library, 2005), 219–308. For the Campaka or Campeyya *Jātaka* see *The Jātaka, or Stories of the Buddha's Former Births*, ed. E. B. Cowell, vol. VI (New Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1895; repr., 1994), 281–90 (no. 506).
- 23 *Ibid.*, vol. V, 84–91 (no. 524); Schlingloff, *Guide to the Ajanta Paintings*, 4.
- 24 Cowell, *Divyāvadāna*, 24, and see Schlingloff, *Guide to the Ajanta Paintings*, 11.
- 25 Cowell, *Jātaka*, vol. VI, 126–55 (no. 545); Schlingloff, *Guide to the Ajanta Paintings*, 19–20.
- 26 Cowell, *Jātaka*, vol. VI, 80–113 (no. 543); Schlingloff, *Guide to the Ajanta Paintings*, 13.
- 27 The popularity of this Śrāvastī scene in later “intrusive” imagery suggests the relationship between *nāgas* and the Buddha continued to be important in the minds of donors. It should also be noted, however, that the 100 or 1000 Buddha motif may be a variant manner of depicting the same tale. Just after he is lauded by the *nāgas*, the Buddha miraculously manifests multiple versions of himself. The motif seems to appear relatively late in the development of the caves.
- 28 *Divine Stories: Divyāvadāna*, trans. A. Rothman, *Classics of Buddhism* (Boston: Wisdom Publications, 2008), 253–86.
- 29 Hajime Nakamura, *Gotama Buddha: A Biography Based on the Most Reliable Texts*, trans. G. Sekimori (Tokyo: Kosei, 2000), 66–67; Schlingloff, *Guide to the Ajanta Paintings*, 17.
- 30 *Ibid.*, 36.
- 31 *Ibid.*, 37.
- 32 *Ibid.*, 23.
- 33 *Ibid.*, 53.
- 34 For an example of an animate Buddha statue see Fa-Hien, *A Record of Buddhist Kingdoms*, trans. L. Legge (1886; repr., Dover Publications, 1965), 56–57. This is one of the versions of the well-known Prasenajit tale.
- 35 *Apocryphal Birth Stories (Paññāsa-Jātaka)*, trans. P. S. Jaini, vol. 2 (London: Pali Text Society, 1986), 114–16. This is a late text of probable Southeast Asian origin but similar tales can be found in the writings of Faxian. Fa-Hien, *A Record of Buddhist Kingdoms: Being an Account by the Chinese Monk Fa-Hien of his travels in India and Ceylon (A.D. 300–414) in search of the Buddhist Books of Discipline*, trans. J. Legge (New York: Dover, 1886; repr., 1965), 55–56.
- 36 Gregory Schopen, *Bones, Stones and Buddhist Monks: Collected Papers on the Archaeology, Epigraphy and Texts of Monastic Buddhism in India* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 1997), 258–78.
- 37 Cohen, “Setting the Three Jewels,” 380.
- 38 It is interesting to note that the donor of Cave 16, Varāhadeva, seems to refer to a similar type of stability in the relationship between the *nāga* and Ajaṇṭā. He writes, “May this cave founded for the Three Jewels, [containing] a flawless gem of a pavilion inside, continue to be inhabited as long as . . . by multitudes of serpent hoods [like] crowding clouds as long as the sun [shines]. . . .” Due to the fragmentary nature of the inscription, it is not entirely clear if he is requesting the continued presence of cloudy serpent hoods at the site or if he is using them as the second part of a simile to emphasize how long his cave will endure. The more probable interpretation is that this is a plea for his cave to survive as long as the sun and rain, but since he juxtaposes *nāgas* and clouds earlier in the inscription, it seems likely that his plea has both religious and meteorological connotations. See Cohen, “Setting the Three Jewels,” 358–62.
- 39 Hiuen Tsiang, *Si-Yu-Ki Buddhist Records of the Western World*, trans. S. Beal, 2 vols. (London: Motilal Banarsidass, 1884), 63–66.
- 40 *Ibid.*, 94. This story was apparently known even in the fourth century during the lifetime of Faxian since he mentions three of his companions made the journey to see the miraculous shadow. Fa-Hien, *Record of Buddhist Kingdoms*, 36.
- 41 *Ibid.*, 51–52.
- 42 See, for example, the *nāga* images placed directly outside the Buddha's shrine in Caves 20 and 26.
- 43 See Cohen, “Nāga,” 370–87, and for a wider discussion of the topic see DeCaroli, *Haunting*.
- 44 Stella Kramrisch, *The Hindu Temple*, vol. 1 (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1946; repr., 1991), 143.
- 45 Diana L. Eck, *Darśan Seeing the Divine Image in India*, 2nd ed. (Chambersburg, PA: Anima Books, 1985), 44–55.
- 46 Richard Gombrich, “The Consecration of a Buddhist Image,” *Journal of Asian Studies* 26, no. 1 (November 1966), 25–26, 33.